HER CITY: MAKING WOMEN VISIBLE IN THE DESIGN OF PUBLIC OPEN SPACES.

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WHO SPEAKS?
WHO LISTENS?

From an epistemological perspective the feminist challenges to planning theory can be seen as corresponding to the hierarchical dualities of (1992):

Theory	⟷	**Practice**
Knowledge	⟷	**Experience**
Private	⟷	**Public**

1. 1993 Vienna World Conference on Human Rights

2. 1993 The General Assembly of the UN adopted the Declaration on the Elimination of Violence against women

3. 1994 the UN Commission on Human Rights established a special report regarding violence against women.

4. 1994 The OAS (Organization of American States) adopted the Inter-American Convention on the Prevention, Punishment, and Eradication of Violence against Women

5. 1994 IACHR special report on Women's rights

6. 1995 Fourth World Women's Conference (Beijing)

7. 1999 Vienna Gender Mainstreaming

8. 2007 Access to Justice for Women Victims of Violence in the Americas

9. 2021 Australia's National Action Plan on Women, Peace and Security

10. 2023 UN Women UK Campaign public spaces need to be safe and inclusive for all

CURRENT TRENDS

95% Of 500 participant in Delhi stated that they usually carry with them an object for self-protection, also how they change their clothes or the times they go out or not to avoid feeling uncomfortable while being out of their homes (Jagori, 2006).

55% A study has shown that 55% of women in the European Union have experienced a form of sexual harassment since the age of 15 (European Parliament, 2018).

71% In the UK, 71% of women experienced sexual harassment in public areas (UN-Women, 2021).

18% Of women always or often feel unsafe when exercising in an outdoor public space

84% 84% of women have experienced sexual harassment in Leeds' city centre, which is higher than the national statistic (Women-Friendly-Leeds, 2021).

PARADOX OF WOMEN'S FEAR

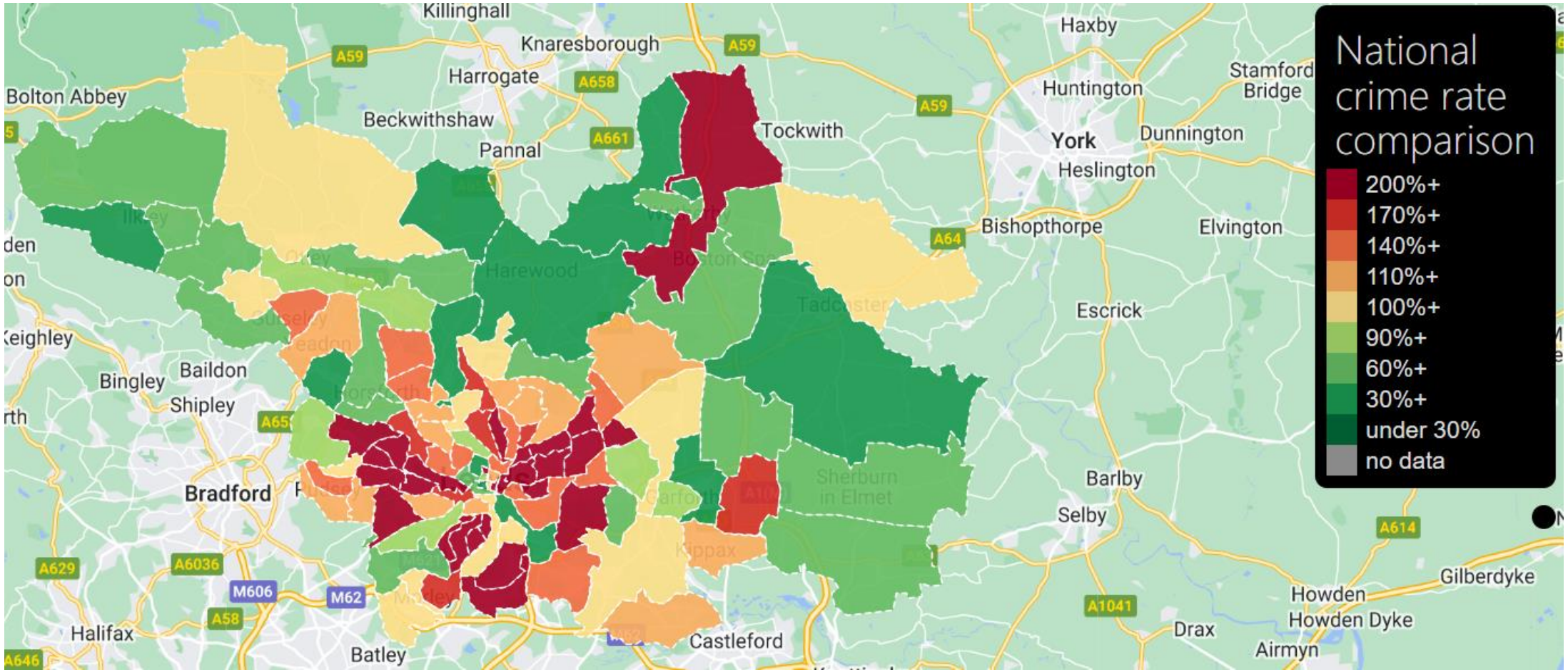
Women who were **less likely than men** to experience **violence in public** and **much more likely** to experience it in **the home**, consistently reported **fear of men in public**.

Feminist perspective **takes power dynamics** into account, **woman's experience** of the threat of **sexual violence** creates the paradox and explains **difference between women's and men's experiences of fear** (Valentine, 1990; Pain, 1991; Madge, 1997; Koskela, 1999; Özascilar, 2013; Kern, 2020)

As Carolyn Whitzman (1996) articulates, **the nature of fear of crime between women and men is different**. "The crime women most fear is rape. The crime that men most fear is robbery. Robbery is a bad thing to have happen to you. Rape is worse."

LEEDS CURRENT SITUATION OF SAFETY IN PUBLIC OPEN SPACES

Most crimes, 44.8k crimes were violent crimes which is 37.8% of all crimes committed in the city.
Violent crime rate is at 153% of national crime rate



WOMEN'S PERCEPTION OF SAFETY IN POS

(Newisar,2024)

WOMEN'S PERCEPTION AND EXPERIENCES OF SAFETY IN POS IN LEEDS

CHART 2: OVERALL, HOW SAFE YOU FEEL WHEN OUT AND ABOUT IN LEEDS DURING THE DAY?

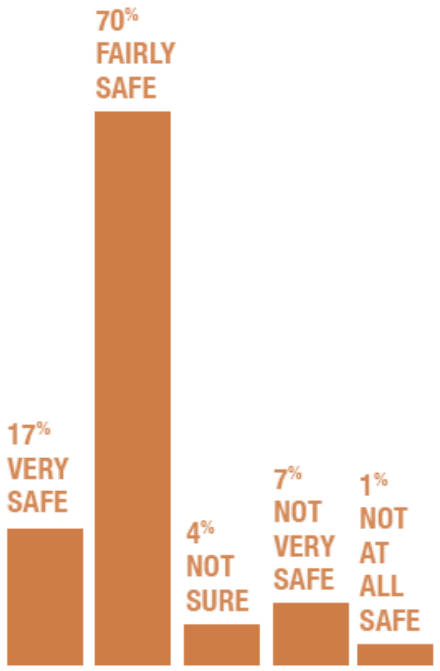


CHART 3: OVERALL, HOW SAFE DO YOU FEEL BEING OUT AND ABOUT IN LEEDS AFTER DARK?

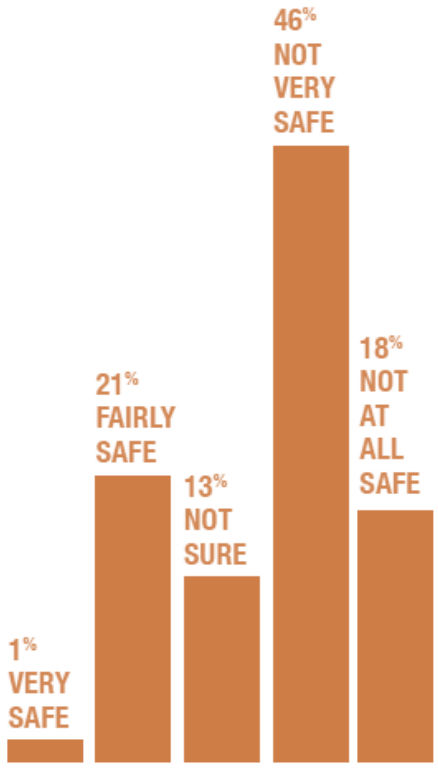
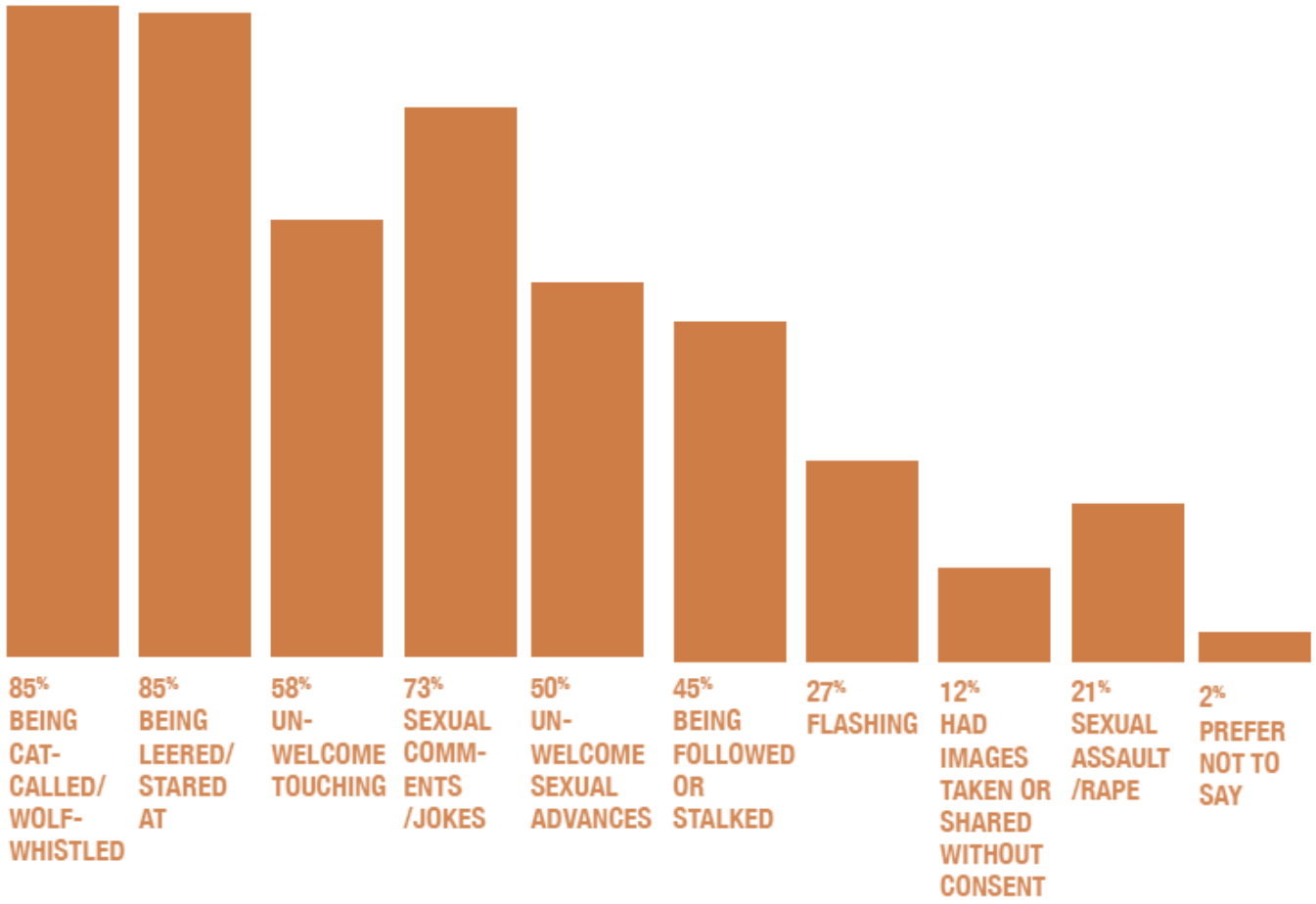
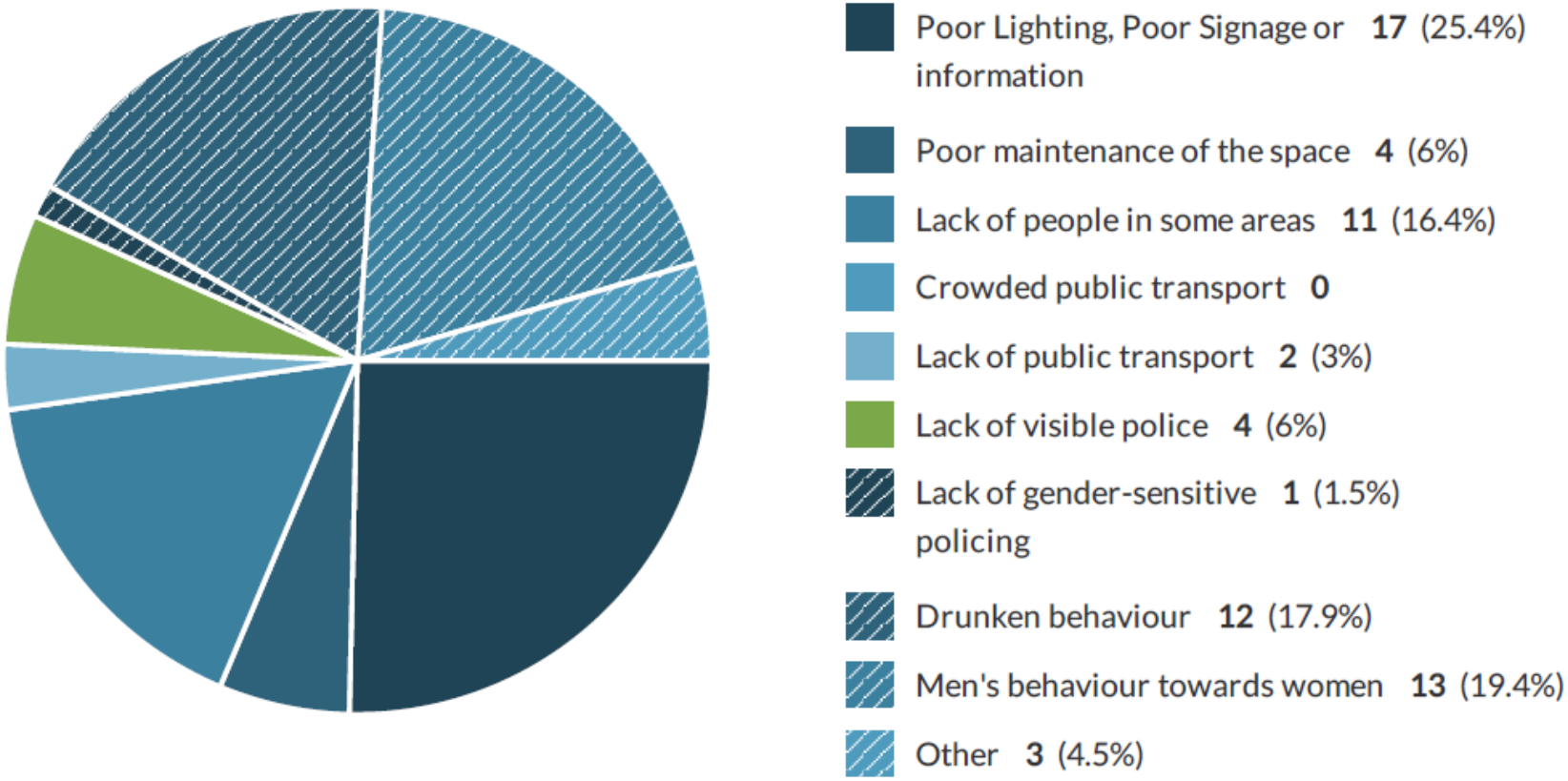


CHART 4: WHICH, IF ANY, OF THE FOLLOWING HAVE YOU EVER PERSONALLY EXPERIENCED?



WOMEN'S PERCEPTION OF SAFETY AND SECURITY IN POS IN LEEDS



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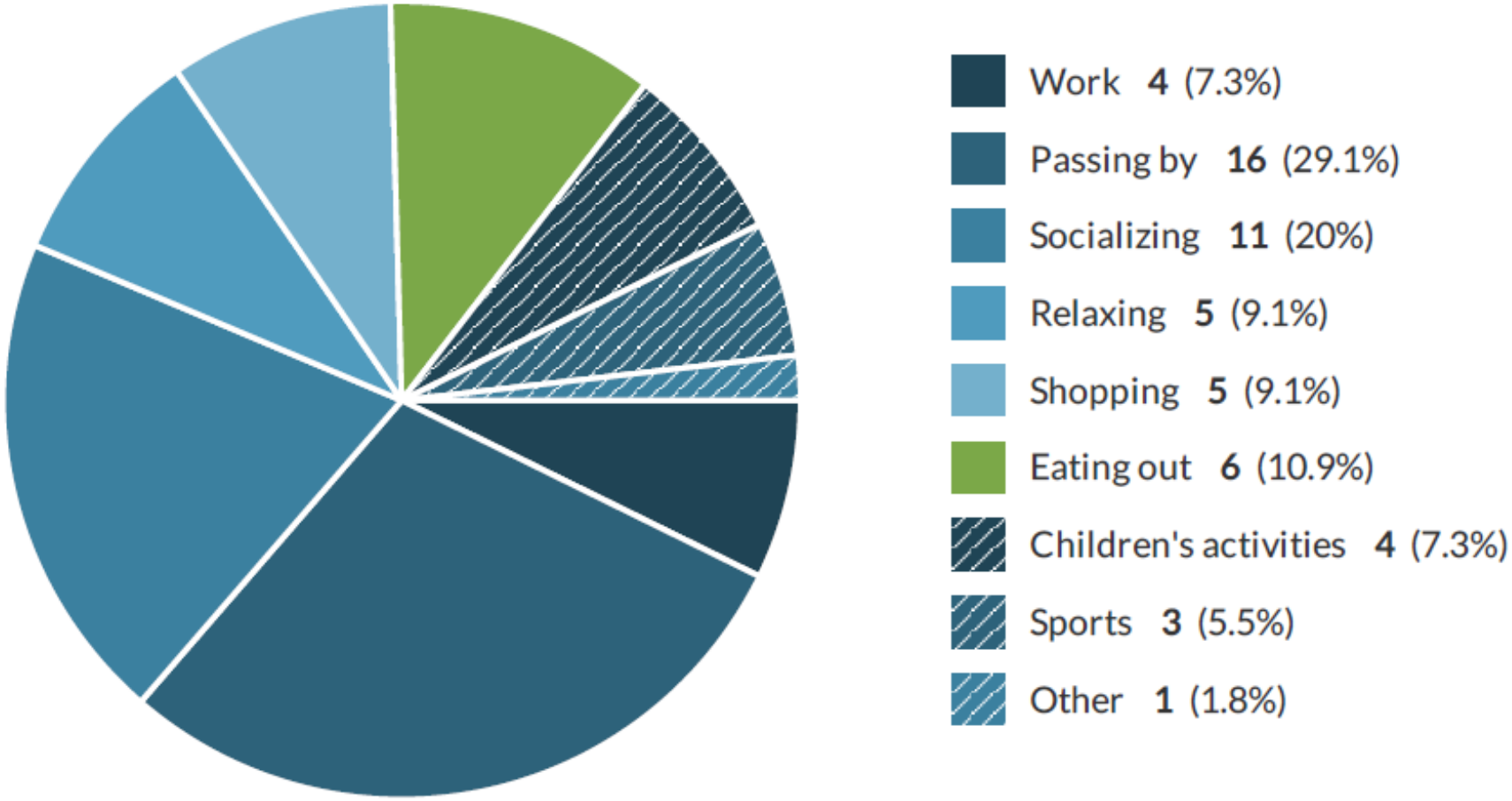


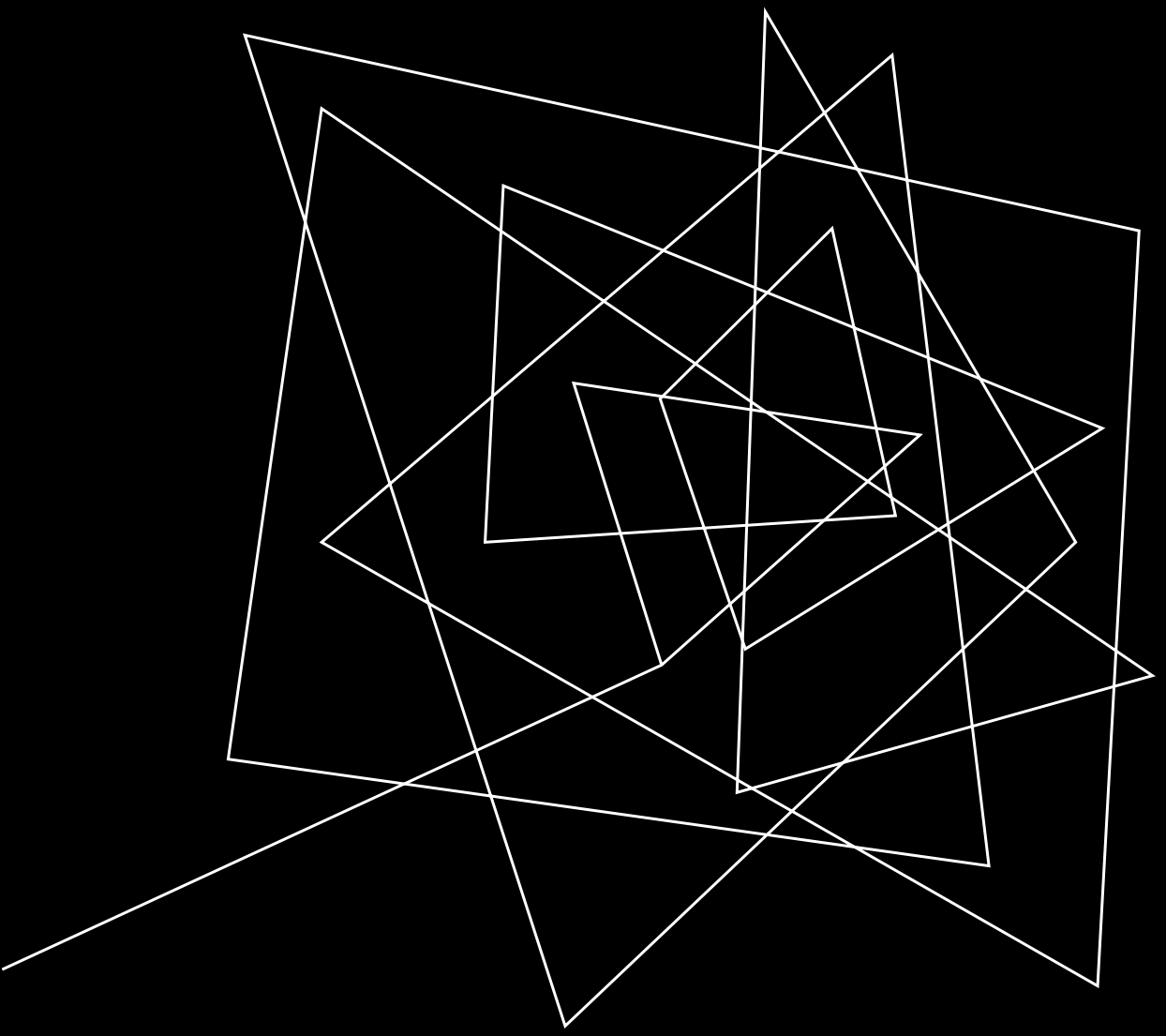
External factors: spatial configuration and socio-cultural constructs

Street network configurations that induce desolated streets can create unconducive environment for women. For instance, the belief within certain cultures that women are more bounded to the domestic realm has curbed women's mobility beyond the home.

Perceptions of safety is highly individualised and subject to personal risk acceptability thresholds in relation to age, physical ability and socio-cultural background.

Internal factors: Individual characteristics and place

Individual characteristics and socio-cultural factors influence how people perceive and attach meaning to places. Positive associations foster place attachment, potentially reducing street crimes and improving safety perceptions.



Engaging with rights and gender in urban planning requires a nuanced approach, avoiding rigid directives that may disconnect from underlying political issues.

A gendered perspective on rights underscores the need for caution regarding the transformative potential of current conceptualisations of the right to the city.

Urban experiences can empower or marginalise, emphasising the political dimensions of everyday life. Can dynamic representations of urban space foster inclusive environments and advance claims to space?

THANK YOU

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